# THE MENACE OF MEOW MEOW

**Gujarat is in the grip of a new drug threat. Not only is Mephedrone passing through the state, it is also being manufactured in its abandoned factories**

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That Gujarat was becoming a transit point for drugs has been an open secret for a while now. As is the fact that synthetic drugs form a significant part of that trade. What is becoming increasingly alarming for the security agencies in the state, however, is the realisation that such drugs are now being produced locally—in rundown godowns and abandoned pharmaceutical factories in Gujarat's hinterland. Among them is the party drug Mephedrone, variously known as 'meow meow', 'white magic', 'M-CAT', 'bubble', or MD.

Between August and December 2022, the Gujarat anti-terrorism squad (ATS) busted two manufacturing units and seized 314 kg of ready-to-consume MD, worth Rs 1,733 crore, along with several tonnes of raw material and machinery from unused pharma factories in Ankleshwar and Vadodara. The Mumbai Police, too, seized 513 kg of MD worth Rs 1,026 crore after a raid on a manufacturing unit in Ankleshwar in August 2022. The seizure of synthetic drugs as well as the number of arrests—148—were the highest in the past year. The Ahmedabad Special Operations Group (SOG) registered 37 drug-related cases in 2022 alone, of which over 50 per cent were MD-related. In total, 22 cases of MD have been registered in the city post January 2022—at least one, and up to three every month, as against none before that, per Jayrajsinh Vala, deputy commissioner of police, SOG, Ahmedabad. Ironically, Ahmedabad had reported 37 cases in total in the five years from 2017 and 2021.

An odourless, white, powdery substance, MD can be mixed with 'gutka', taken with alcohol, snorted, wrapped in paper and swallowed, or 'bombed'. "It leads to hallucinations," says a seasoned Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) cop. "One feels like they are literally flying." This high is what makes it a popular party drug. It can also be consumed in full public view, since it has no smell or smoke, and therefore does not arouse any suspicion. Compare this with heroin, which requires a syringe, or cocaine, which needs to be snorted and has a distinct odour, or ganja and charas, which need a chillum, or even cough syrups, where the trail of empty bottles can possibly lead to their inebriated consumer.

MD doesn't come cheap, though. The street